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Charles humane society celebrates 50 years

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A cat looks up while Rayanne Benya, president of the board of directors for the Humane Society of Charles County, is hosting a gala on Oct. 10 at the Waldorf Jaycees.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

While many things have changed over the last half century, one constant has been the care provided to animals by the Humane Society of Charles County.

The nonprofit organization is hosting its Golden Paws Gala on Oct. 10 to celebrate 50 years of taking care of sick, injured and homeless animals.

The event is from 6 p.m. to 10 p.m. at the Waldorf Jaycees at 3090 Crain Highway. Tickets are \$75 per person.

Local humane societies are not directly attached to the National Humane Society, making the Humane Society of Charles County 100% reliant on local donations, grants and fundraising, Rayanne Benya, president of the board of directors for the Humane Society of Charles County, said.

In 1975, the humane society did not have a building. Instead, people who found an injured animal had to take them home, Anne Gardiner, founder of the Humane Society of Charles County, said. In 1981, the St. Charles County Association of Realtors gave the humane society the land for a shelter and it opened in 1983.

“It was tough getting started,” Gardiner said. “One time I had [animals] in all three bathrooms and we were wondering what we were going to do.”

The humane society has three sections: the kennel, which houses animals ranging from dogs and cats to guinea pigs, rabbits, lizards, turtles and snakes; the humane education program, which teaches students about animals and environmental science; and the clinic.

“Fifty years later, we’re still here,” Benya said. “We’re here because we’re supported by the residents of the county ... and I think that’s something to celebrate.”

The gala will have a silent auction with dog baskets, Gardiner said. Other baskets will have household items. Wine and alcohol will be raffled, and there will also be gift cards for restaurants and businesses.

Live music will be performed by the “Original” Moonlighters and there will be a lipsologist — a person who “reads” lip prints — and a cash bar. Food is being donated by the Waldorf Jaycees.

“It’s just for a great cause,” Benya said. “We adopt out anywhere from one to 2,000 animals a year and all those animals need medical care.”

Under the shelter’s care, the humane society often has about 150 animals, an amount that can go up to 250 animals during the summer, Benya said.

Throughout the year, the shelter has around 200 volunteers who help with adoption events, laundry and being around the animals. They also want to build an animal medical facility for emergencies and a larger surgery wing.

“When [people] come here and they volunteer, they see the connection ... between humans and animals,” Benya said.

The humane society is holding its annual photo contest until Sept. 27, Benya said. People can send a cute photo of their pet that can be featured in a calendar.

On Sept. 20, they will have an adoption event at the humane society, Benya said.

The nonprofit also has a program called Freedom Friends year round that offers discounts to veterans to adopt animals for animals that have been in the shelter for six months or longer.

“It’s important that we receive the funding ... so we can continue to be here for the county,” Benya said. “If we disappear, that’s going to be devastating for the animal population.

For more information about the Oct. 10 gala or to purchase tickets, go to humanesocietycc.org.
